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GENERAL PAPER

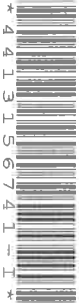
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Paper 2

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Singapore Examinations and Assessment Board



CAMBRIDGE
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A journalist investigates why millennials across the rich world are failing to vote.

[The term 'millennials' denotes people reaching young adulthood in the early twenty-first century.]

- 1 The life story of Alex Orlyuk does not seem destined to lead to political apathy. Born in the Soviet Union to a family scarred by the Holocaust, he moved at the age of six to Tel Aviv, Israel, where he finished school and military service. He follows politics and prizes democracy. He thinks his government should do more to make peace with Palestinians, separate religion and state, and cut inequality. And yet, now aged 28 and eligible to vote in the past four general elections, he has never cast a ballot. His abstention, he says, is 'a political statement' on the sorry state of Israel's politics. He does not think any of its myriad parties is likely to bring about the change he wants. Many other young Israelis share his disaffection. Just 41% of under-25s voted in the general election of 2013, compared with 88% of over-55s. No other rich country has a bigger gap in turnout between under-25s and over-55s. 5 10
- 2 Though Israeli politics is atypical—steeped in questions of war, peace, religious identity and the relationship with Palestinians—the voting behaviour of its young is nevertheless all of a pattern with the rest of the rich world. Although turnout has been generally declining across the rich world, it has fallen faster among the young. Recent evidence from Britain, Poland, Switzerland and America showed that more than half of millennials stayed at home on election day. Demographic trends further weaken the political voice of the young. In America's election in 1972, the first in which 18-year-olds could vote, around a fifth of adults were under 25. However, by 2050 under-25s are projected to make up just a tenth of American adults. As a result, the young will have dwindled from a pivotal voting bloc into a peripheral one which raises the worrying possibility that today's record-low youth turnout presages a permanent shift. Voting habits are formed surprisingly early—in a person's first two elections. If future generations, discouraged by their fading influence, never adopt the voting habit, turnout will fall further, weakening the legitimacy of elected governments. 15 20 25
- 3 Millennials are not the first young generation to be accused of shirking their civic duty. Whilst they are more interested in issues and causes than they are given credit for, are better educated than past generations, are more likely to go on a protest or to become vegetarian, and are less keen on drugs and alcohol, millennials seldom establish the habits that inclined their parents to vote. People who have children and own a home feel more attached to their communities and are more concerned about how they are run. But youngsters are settling down later than their parents did. 30
- 4 The biggest shift, however, is not in circumstances but in attitudes. Millennials do not see voting as a duty, and therefore do not feel morally obliged to do it. Rather, they regard it as the duty of politicians to woo them. They see parties not as movements deserving of loyalty, but as brands they can choose between or ignore. Millennials are accustomed to tailoring their world to their preferences, such as customising the music they listen to and the news they consume. A system that demands they vote for an all-or-nothing bundle of election promises looks uninviting by comparison. 35
- 5 Many disillusioned youngsters regard refusing to vote as a way to express dissatisfaction with the choices on offer. But abstention traps them in a cycle of neglect and alienation. Politicians know that the elderly are more likely to vote, and so tailor their policies accordingly. Young people, seeing a system that offers them little, are even more likely to tune out, which gives parties more reason to ignore them. Some parties disregard the young completely. In the Netherlands, the party 50PLUS campaigns almost exclusively on pensioners' issues and is polling in double figures. 40 45



- 6 Even parties without any such overt focus on old people increasingly favour them when setting policies. Australians aged over 65 pay no tax on income under \$24 508; younger workers start paying tax at \$15 650. In Britain, free bus passes, television licences and energy subsidies for pensioners have survived government cutbacks; housing assistance for young workers has not. Young workers pay taxes toward health-care and pension schemes that are unlikely to be equally generous by the time they retire. 50
- 7 Those fretting about the future of democracy have been searching for ways to get more young people to vote. The most obvious would be to make voting compulsory, as it is in Australia, Belgium, Brazil and many other countries. Barack Obama has said such a move would be 'transformative' for America, boosting the voices of the young and the poor. But it could be argued that such a move would artificially boost turnout without dealing with the underlying causes. The London School of Economics argues that the priority should be to inspire a feeling among young people 'that the system listens to you and reacts to you', which in turn would strengthen political commitment. 55
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- 8 One place to build such a belief is in school. Teenagers who experience democracy first-hand during their studies are more likely to vote afterwards. Student elections make young people feel they have the power to shape the institutions around them. Civic-education curricula which involve open discussions and debates are better at fostering political engagement in later life than classes dedicated to imparting facts about government institutions. Yet schools and governments, wary of accusations of politicising the classroom, may shy away from such programmes. 65
- 9 Another option would be to allow people to vote even younger. In many countries, voting habits are formed during a particularly unsettled period of young people's lives: the few years after leaving school. Argentina, Austria and other countries are trying to ingrain voting habits earlier by lowering the minimum age to 16. This lets young people cast their first votes while still in school and living with their parents. In Austria, the only European country to let 16- and 17-year-olds vote nationwide, they have proved more likely than 18- to 20-year-olds to turn out in the first election for which they qualify to vote. 70
- 10 As millennials find fewer reasons to vote, motivating them to do so is becoming dangerously dependent on individual politicians and single issues. Mr Orlyuk fondly recalls Yitzhak Rabin (a former Israeli prime minister who was assassinated when Mr Orlyuk was seven) for 'trying to make a change' by making peace with Palestinians. 'I'm still waiting for another Rabin to come along. Then I'll vote,' he says. In the meantime, politicians will find the opinions and interests of young people all too easy to ignore. 75
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